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Plural marriage among the Wolof in the Gambia

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CHAPTER IV THE STATUS OF MEN AND WOMEN IN GENERAL AND OF THE HUSBAND AND PLURAL WIVES

Women have little to do with the administration of village affairs or the settlement of disputes. They do not go to English schools in the Protectorate any more than to the Koranic schools. Elders say, "Why does a woman need an education to bear children, pound grain, and draw water?" ¹³

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Women were observed to show many overt forms of deference to men. They do not eat out of the same bowl, and ordinarily eat in a separate house. When a woman meets an elder, she is expected to curtsey and greet him respectfully. A man does not give an older woman such consideration, though he will not joke with her or take other liberties as he does with younger women. If a woman wishes to greet a group of men in public places or in the house of the husband, she must remain standing. Women rarely sit down and talk with a group  99 of men, usually keep apart at ceremonies and at other public functions, and do not walk about at night except in groups, when attending wrestling matches or other public functions. Yet women are not veiled or kept in seclusion, like the Muslim women of North Africa and the Near East. The important role of the Wolof women in the economic sphere of activities precludes these restrictions on their behavior.

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¹³ The elders are similarly reluctant to send their sons to the British schools for fear that the sons will leave home upon graduation and go to an urban center, like Bathurst, to work for the white men rather than for their fathers.

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